

The Manus recipes — what they are and the one number that mattered

Four reproduction recipes Manus wrote for its own work, saved 15 Aug 2026 before the free window closed. **The PDFs are the source of truth.** The .txt files beside them are extracted text for searching — text extraction mangled some digits (they appear as ■), so read a number off the PDF, never off the .txt.

Recipe	Episode
Nia_Photo_Series_and_Captioned_Video___Reproduction_Recipe.pdf	3 — the fullest one, 13 pages. Start here.
Nia_Photo_Story___Exact_Task_Record_and_Reproduction_Recipe.pdf	3 — the task record
Eli_Story_Series___Reproduction_Recipe.pdf	5 — gaming
Reproducibility_Recipe_Meg_Lily...OST.pdf	6 — work

Why these were captured

Manus was free until 25 Aug 2026. The films are nice; **the commands are the asset**. A recipe can be run on any machine with ffmpeg, forever, for nothing.

THE FINDING: the camera move is 2%, not 25%

The whole "cinematic" feel comes from one number. Manus's Ken Burns move is:

```
zoom in : min(zoom+0.00022,1.02)
zoom out: max(1.02-on*0.00022,1.0)
pan      : x='iw/2-(iw/zoom/2)';y='ih/2-(ih/zoom/2)'
frame    : d=1:s=1440x2560:fps=30
prep     : scale=1440:2560:force_original_aspect_ratio=increase,crop=1440:2560
```

That is a 2% zoom across a 5-second shot. Barely perceptible — the frame breathes rather than moves.

Studio's default was **0.25 — twelve times more movement**, and even its "Barely there" setting was 0.08, four times more. That difference is most of why Manus's films looked composed and Studio's looked like a slideshow.

Fixed in b0867: Studio's Ken Burns menu now opens with **"Almost still — 2%"** and it is the default. If a shot ever needs more, the old settings are still in the list.

The rest of the pipeline, as recorded

- **Working resolution 1440×2560**, not 1080×1920 — rendered larger, which keeps the zoom from softening the image.
- **Captions are burned in with** drawtext, not a subtitle stream. DejaVu Sans, centred, sat near y=h-400, with a backing box, and a **0.3s fade in / 0.35s fade out per shot**. Those fades are the second thing that makes it feel edited rather than generated.
- **Assembly is three passes:** render each shot to its own mp4 → concat demuxer with -c copy → mix the music → tpad=stop_mode=clone to hold the last frame for the end card.
- **H.264, veryfast, CRF (no fixed bitrate), yuv420p, +faststart.**

- Verified with `ffprobe` — recorded output `duration=53.000000`.

What to do with them

- 1. Keep them.** They cost nothing to store and cannot be regenerated once the free window closes.
- 2. Port the good parts into Studio**, one at a time. The 2% zoom is done. The caption fades are the next candidate.
- 3.** Anything ported gets a note in `START-HERE.md` saying where it came from, so nobody "tidies" it back to a default that looks worse.